

# Step 2: Propose High-Level Design & Get Buy-In

In this step, the goal is to design a **high-level architecture** and align it with the interviewer. This is a **collaborative phase**, not a final solution.

## Core Goal

- Build an initial system blueprint
- Get feedback from interviewer
- Refine architecture based on discussion
- Validate scalability assumptions

None

Goal = Shared understanding of system design

## Key Mindset

- Treat interviewer as a teammate
- Think out loud
- Continuously ask for feedback
- Be open to modifying design

None

System design = collaborative discussion, not solo solution

# Step 2 Approach

## 1. High-Level Blueprint

Start by drawing a simple architecture with major components:

- Clients (Web / Mobile)
- Load Balancer
- API Gateway
- Application Servers
- Database
- Cache
- Message Queue
- CDN (if needed)

None

Client → Load Balancer → App Servers → DB / Cache / Queue

## 2. Break into Subsystems

Decompose system into logical layers:

None

Frontend → API Layer → Service Layer → Data Layer

### 3. Validate with Interviewer

Ask:

- “Does this architecture look good?”
- “Should we add caching or messaging here?”
- “Any concerns about scalability?”

None

Design improves through feedback loop

### 4. Back-of-the-Envelope Estimation

Estimate system scale before finalizing design:

- QPS
- Storage
- Bandwidth

None

Estimate → Validate → Adjust architecture

### 5. Use Case Walkthrough

Simulate real flows:

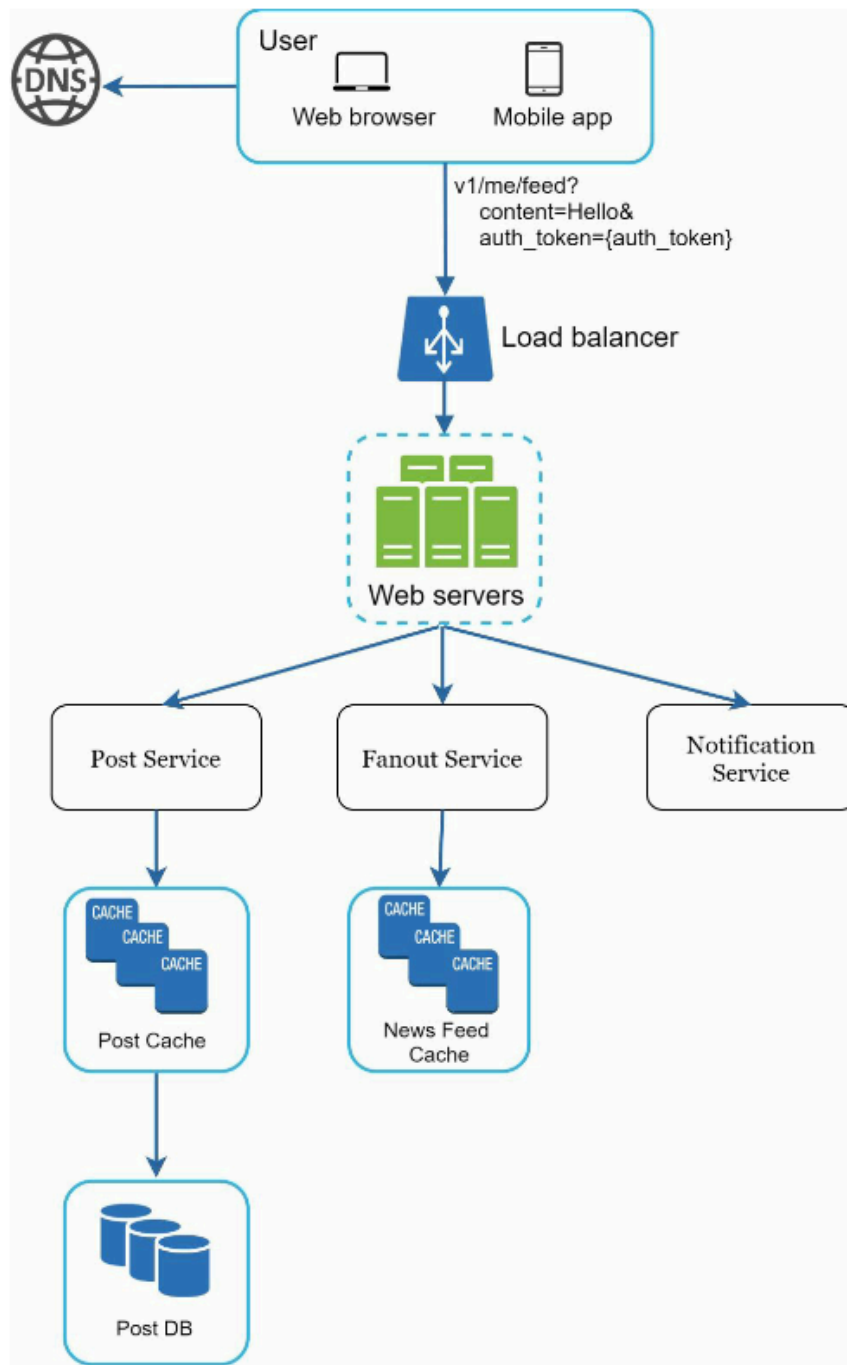
- User posts content
- User reads feed
- System processes and distributes updates

None

Use case validation ensures design completeness

# News Feed Example (High-Level Design)

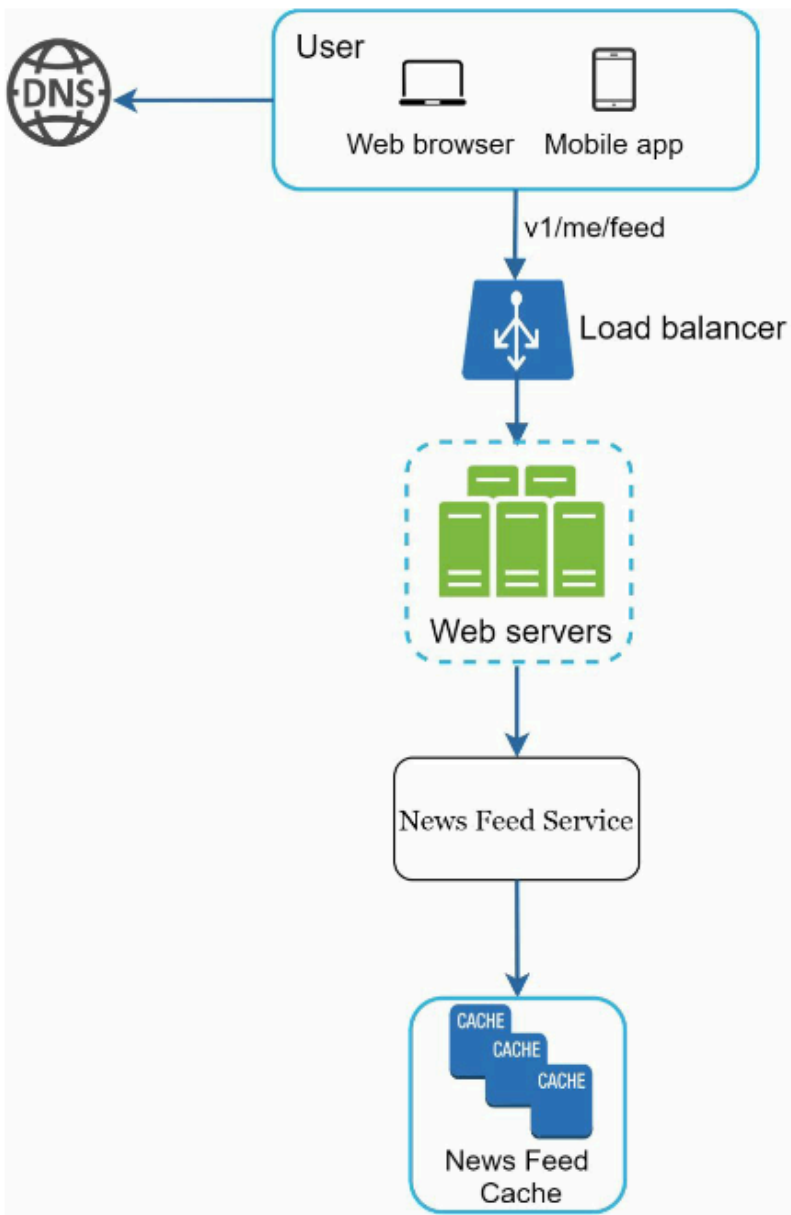
## Feed Publishing Flow



None

User → Load Balancer → Web Servers → Different Services →  
Cache → DB

## News Feed Building Flow



None

User → Load Balancer → Web Servers → News Feed Service → News Feed Cache

## Key Insight

None

Good high-level design = simple architecture + clear data flow + scalability validation + iterative refinement

## Mental Model

None

Requirements → High-level architecture → Figure-based flow design → Validation → Refinement

## One-Line Summary

**Step 2 is about proposing a high-level system architecture, validating it with the interviewer, and refining it using discussion, scalability checks, and use-case flows.**